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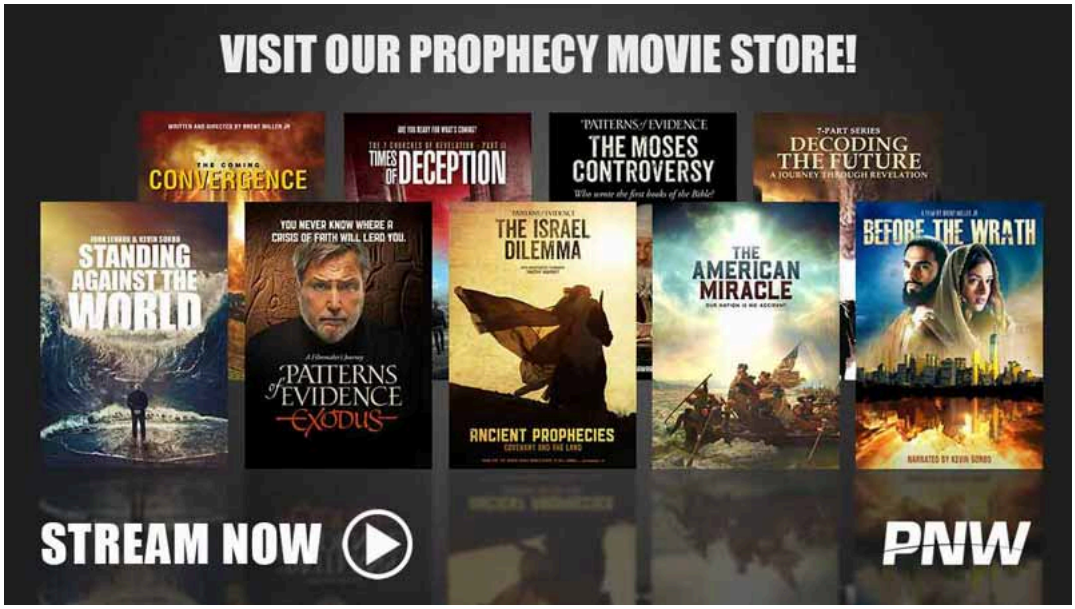

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Why Are Democrats Trying To Criminalize Investigative Journalism?

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BY JIM HOFT/WND NEWS CENER APRIL 15, 2026

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Instead of fixing the fraud problems being uncovered, politicians are trying to shut down the people exposing them

The radical Left in Sacramento has finally done it.

In a move straight out of a totalitarian playbook, the California Assembly Judiciary Committee voted 11-2 on Monday to advance AB 2624, the so-called "Stop Nick Shirley Act," a Democrat power grab designed to make it illegal for brave citizen journalists like Nick Shirley to expose the rampant fraud bleeding American taxpayers dry in immigrant service centers.

This is nothing less than an all-out assault on the First Amendment by the radical left in the People's Republic of California.

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Lula Lona

The bill, authored by far-left Assemblywoman Mia Bonta (wife of Attorney General Rob Bonta), would slap investigative reporters with massive civil sanctions starting at $4,000 minimum if a fraudster from one of these "immigrant service centers" decides they don't want to be caught on camera committing their scams.

The crook can then run to court for an injunction banning the journalist from filming or exposing them on camera for up to four years.

And if the journalist refuses to take down the original video? Triple the damages, $12,000, just for telling the truth!

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What a disgrace! This is Democrats in action: protecting fraud artists over the American people.

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California State Assembly member Carl DeMaio is among those raising urgent concerns about the legislation, warning that AB 2624 (Bonta) represents a dangerous escalation in government efforts to control investigative reporting.

CA State Assembly member Carl DeMaio is slamming state Democrats for voting to advance a controversial new law (AB 2624) to silence citizen journalists and shield taxpayer-funded organizations from public scrutiny.

DeMaio has gone as far as dubbing AB 2624 the "Stop Nick Shirley Act" for the chilling effect it will have on free speech.

AB 2624 comes as independent journalists like Nick Shirley have used viral videos to expose fraud and abuse in government-funded programs using on-the-ground footage and firsthand documentation.

AB 2624 claims to be about protecting immigrant organizations from "threats of violence," when in fact the legislation would apply to any left-wing group that claims to provide any services to legal or illegal immigrants. For example, under AB 2624 entities like the Somali "Learning" Daycare centers would all be covered if they operated inside California.

During a recent Assembly committee hearing, DeMaio directly confronted the bill's author, Mia Bonta, over language that would allow individuals affiliated with certain organizations to demand the removal of video recordings -- even if taken in public -- and even impose costly financial penalties against those who publish the videos online.

DeMaio warned the bill would be used to block investigative reporting and intimidate journalists, watchdog groups, and members of the public documenting wrongdoing.

Assembly member Carl DeMaio's Full Statement on AB 2624:

"California Democrats are trying to intimidate citizen watchdog journalists and protect waste and fraud happening in far-Left-wing NGOs. AB 2624 can only be described as the 'Stop Nick Shirley Act' -- a bill designed to silence citizen journalists exposing fraud and abuse of taxpayer dollars.

Instead of fixing the fraud problems being uncovered, Sacramento politicians are trying to shut down the people exposing them.

AB 2624 would allow activists and taxpayer-funded organizations to demand the removal of video evidence -- even if it captures misconduct in plain view -- and threatens journalists with massive financial penalties.

That's not about public safety -- it's about protecting powerful interests.

If this bill becomes law, the message is clear to every journalist in California: expose corruption and you will be punished. AB 2624 is an unconstitutional direct attack on transparency and the First Amendment - and it needs to be defeated."

Nick Shirley blew the lid off over $110 million in Somali daycare fraud in Minnesota back in December 2025, empty facilities billing taxpayers while kids were nowhere to be found.

He faced death threats and doxxing for his work, which we reported on extensively. Then in March 2026, Shirley dropped another bombshell: $170 million in similar fraud in California daycares and hospices, with ghost operations registered to empty lots and strip malls.

Originally published at WND News Center (https://www.wnd.com/2026/04/expose-corruption-you-will-be-punished-radical-democrats)

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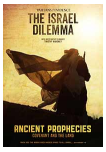

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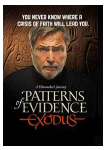

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